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Listening Bar Trend

The Second-Round "Slow One"

New Venue Type

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This Issue From Tokyo to Seoul — the "Listening Bar" arrives: a new kind of drinking occasion built on time spent with music

CONTENTS

Overview & Summary

01 Trend Diagnosis — What a "Listening Bar" Is, and Why It Spread from Tokyo

The 100-year revival of the ongaku kissa; a generation choosing bars over clubs

02 Why Korea, Why Now — Three Tailwinds

Shifting second-round culture · vinyl revival · lower tax on low-ABV drinks

03 Tokyo Field Notes — Ginza Music Bar · Shibuya Record Bar

Drinks, prices and menus of two Tokyo listening bars seen first-hand

04 Seoul Listening-Bar Map — Five Already Here

Jongno · Euljiro · Haebangchon · Apgujeong · Hannam — real venues by district

05 The Drinks a Listening Bar Calls For — Small-Batch Premium

Craft beer · whisky highball · natural wine · premium sake

06 Channel Strategy — New Bars / Music-Paired Dining / Vinyl Pubs

Tailored proposals by channel + direct lines to your account manager

07 Maximizing Venue Sales — Six Proposals for Listening Bars

Sound + pairing · signature highball · LP nights · non-alcoholic option

08 About Sewang & Contacts for 13 Sales Managers

Full-line liquor wholesale for Seoul/Gyeonggi · direct lines by district

This Issue in One Sentence

▲ New Venue Type

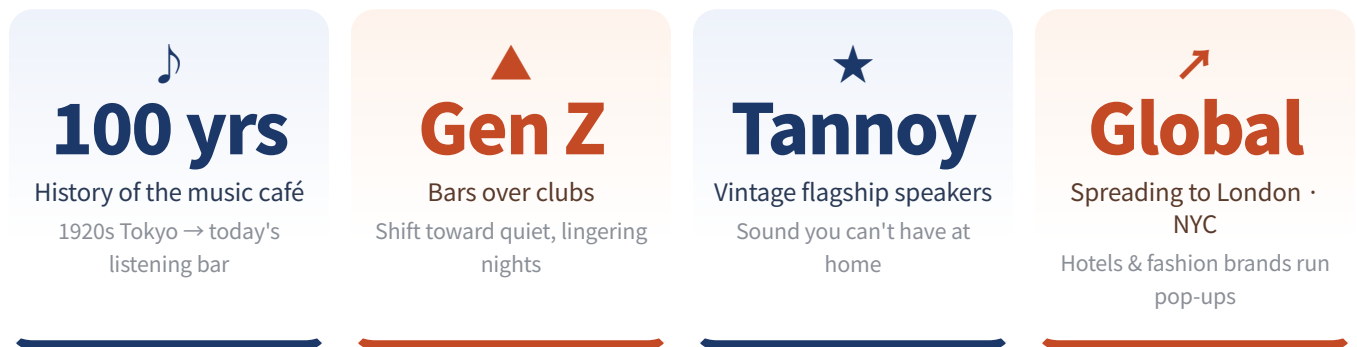
"Drink hard and fast" is fading; **drinking occasions built on slowly spending time with music** are rising. Proven in Tokyo, the **listening bar** is a second-round venue calling for "a light, good single drink" — for Sewang, an opportunity to win new accounts with a bundle of **craft beer, highball, natural wine and sake**.

What a "Listening Bar" Is, and Why It Spread from Tokyo

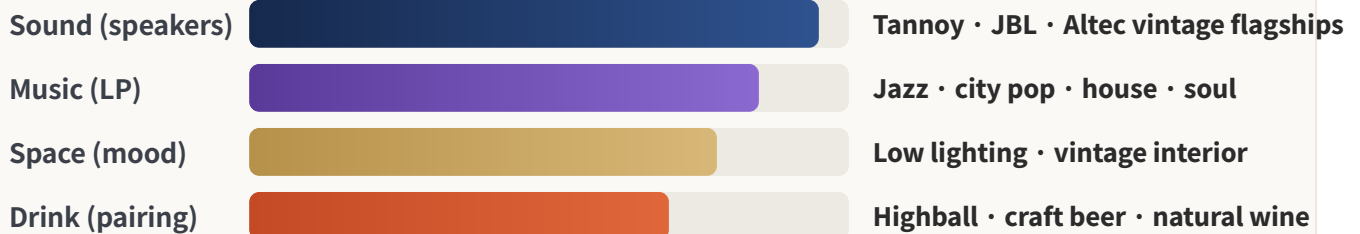
A bar where you "listen" to music on high-end speakers. Japan's 100-year-old ongaku kissa (music café) has returned in sleek interiors as Gen Z night culture.

One-line definition — a place you go to "listen," not just to "drink"

A listening bar is a venue where **music is the main act**, played through vintage speakers and LPs on a turntable. The opposite of a loud club — good sound, low lighting and a single drink make it an **"immersive music space."**



The four elements of a listening bar



Bar lengths illustrate the relative weight of each element in the concept. The point: sound and music lead, while drinks extend the time guests stay.

KEY

Tokyo landmarks like **Bar Martha (Ebisu)** and **Studio Mule (Shibuya)** have become audiophile pilgrimage sites, and in 2025 even a **mobile listening bar** — a classic Mini towing a "listening room" — appeared. Global brands such as Valentino and Virgin Hotels borrow the format for pop-ups, a sign of how **proven** the trend is.

Sources: Smithsonian Magazine "Why Gen Z Is Trading Night Clubs for Listening Bars" · The World (PRX) "Japan's listening lounges" 2025-02 · Corner · PUNCH "Tokyo listening bars" · Citizen Femme 2025-04 · ※ Some content is interpretive, based on press coverage.

Why Korea, Why Now — Three Tailwinds

Korea already has the soil for listening bars to take root. Changing drinking culture, the vinyl revival and tax policy all line up at once.

SHIFT IN CONSUMPTION

Binge ↓
Taste ↑

Drinking frequency and volume fall, but the grain of consumption shifts to "less, but better, and slower."

①

Changing second-round culture — fewer hard-drinking after-parties; more lingering "one more, lightly" after dinner

②

Vinyl revival — an LP boom led by people in their 20s–30s; LP bars spreading in Seochon, Haebangchon, Seongsu

③

Lower tax on low-ABV drinks — a policy tailwind for highballs and craft beer (see below)

Market currents supporting listening bars

Whisky · highball		"Highball bar" now an established category ▲
Japanese beer		No. 1 imported beer 3 years running ▲
Craft beer		Recovery expected from tax cut ▲
Natural wine		Pairs with vinyl bars & dining ▲
LP · vinyl		20s–30s revival continues ▲

※ Categories use different sources and bases — bars show direction of growth, not absolute comparison.

POLICY

The government will **cut the liquor tax by 30%** on a temporary basis **from April 2026 through end-2028** for drinks of 8.5% ABV or less (with ≥ 2 non-volatile content). Highballs and craft beer — **the core menu of a listening bar — benefit directly.**

Sources: Kuki News "Lighter liquor consumption" 2026-02-19 · Daum/News "Highball tax cut ... craft beer" 2026-01-21 · Hankook Ilbo "Gen MZ LP boom" · Hankyung · Sommelier Times Japanese-beer / craft-beer coverage · ※ Policy and figures may vary by time.

Ginza Music Bar · Shibuya Record Bar

Two Tokyo listening bars seen first-hand by our CEO. Drinks, price ranges and menus are transcribed exactly, so you can apply them to a Seoul venue right away.



GINZA MUSIC BAR

Address Chuo City Ginza 7-8-13, Brown Place
4F

Price ¥2,000 –
7,000

Drinks TPM · Yona Yona Ale · craft
beer

Menu Small plates · bar snacks · cheese
platters

INSIGHT A flagship LP/vinyl listening bar · Famous for Tannoy speakers · High photo/branding value · Well known to foreign visitors · Classic Tokyo nightlife mood



SHIBUYA RECORD BAR ANALOG

Address Realize Building 3F, 2-20-9 Dogenzaka,
Shibuya-ku

Price ¥2,000 –
3,000

Drinks Asahi · Japanese craft
beer

Menu Small plates · bar snacks · finger
food

INSIGHT A signature Shibuya record-bar culture space · LP-centered, immersive music experience · Dark lighting, vintage interior · Music-fashion-lifestyle blend · City pop, jazz, house · **Tokyo Gen-MZ listening-bar mood**

How to read it — what both venues share

▲ ¥2,000+ per head

Both lay down **craft beer as the base line** and, with cover charges included, build a spend of **over ¥2,000 per guest**. The revenue driver isn't expensive food but "**great music + one or two good beers**" — a model that delivers high per-head spend even with few seats.

Sources: CEO-provided Tokyo field material (two listening bars, Ginza & Shibuya) · venue signage / Google Maps. Prices and menus may change from the time of visit.

Seoul Listening-Bar Map — Five Already Here

Listening bars aren't a distant idea. Real venues are already established in Jongno, Euljiro, Haebangchon, Apgujeong and Hannam. (Addresses verified via Naver Local.)

Soulville Listening Bar Jongno · Seochon

19-11 Sajik-ro 12-gil, Jongno-gu, Seoul, 1F

A true music-listening bar with "listening bar" in its name. **Soul/funk LPs** keep guests lingering — a good fit for **craft beer and highball** turnover.

Pyeonggyunyul (PKY) Euljiro · Chungmuro

3 Chungmu-ro 4-gil, Jung-gu, Seoul (Oldies Taco bldg, 2F)

A signature Euljiro music bar — "no one goes only once." A music-led space that suits **small-batch premium curation**.

SEOUL VINYL Haebangchon

30 Sinheung-ro, Yongsan-gu, Seoul, 1F

An LP bar and record shop in one. A vinyl-lovers' landmark with **high recognition among foreign visitors**. Strong potential for natural wine and craft beer pairings.

Cotton Club Apgujeong Rodeo Apgujeong

14 Apgujeong-ro 54-gil, Gangnam-gu, Seoul, B1

A jazz/LP-mood music bar in Gangnam. A district where premium pricing holds — ideal for **whisky and premium sake** curation.

Sounds Hannam (listening space) Hannam

35 Daesagwan-ro, Yongsan-gu, Seoul

Listening and music content inside a cultural complex. Combined with dining and lounges, it's a district with strong demand for **natural wine, mocktails and non-alcoholic** pairings.

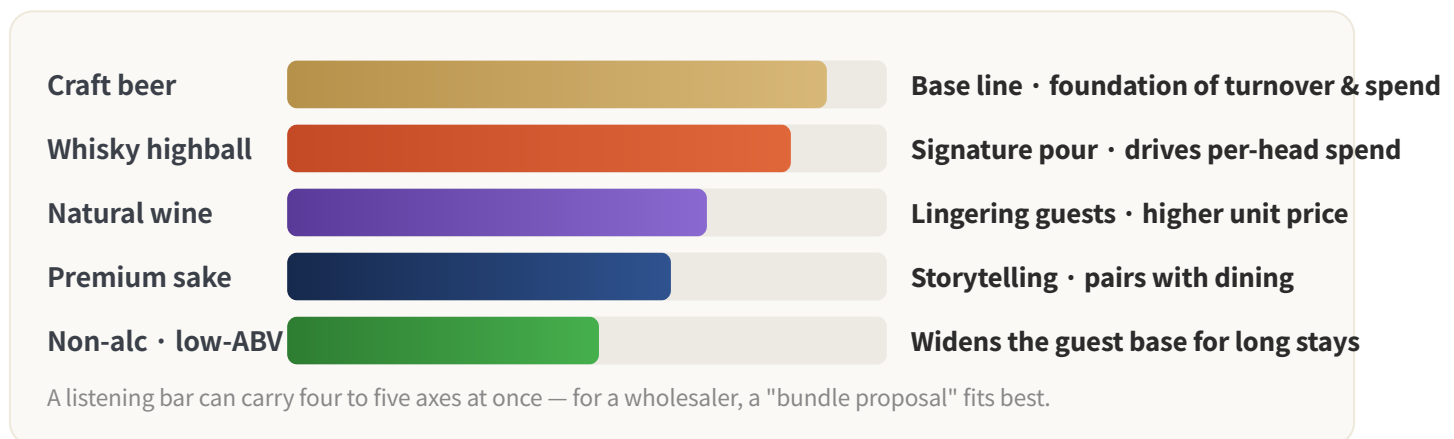
Sources: Naver Local (place search) verified for address/business type (2026-06-16) · press LP-bar / music-bar features. Hours and concepts may change — confirm before visiting.

The Drinks a Listening Bar Calls For — Small-Batch Premium

A listening bar's drinks are about "doing it right," not "drinking a lot." One or two drinks that extend the stay — exactly what Sewang supplies best.



A listening bar's drink lineup — four axes



Sewang's proposal — a listening-bar bundle

▲ Hold the price

① **Craft & Japanese-beer base line** — Asahi, Suntory, Yona Yona for baseline sales · ② **Signature highball kit** (whisky + tonic + glass) to lift per-head spend · ③ **Natural wine & premium sake** curated small-batch with tasting notes · ④ **Bottled non-alcoholic** for the longest-staying guests. Sewang supplies it all in one bundle.

Sources: Hankyung · Sommelier Times Japanese-beer share coverage · Daum "Highball tax cut" 2026-01-21 · Asia Economy · Kuki News whisky/highball coverage · ※ Figures are estimates from press/customs and may vary by time.

Channel Strategy

Tailored proposals by channel — new listening/music bars / music-paired dining & izakaya / vinyl pubs & wine bars + direct lines to your manager.

CHANNEL 01



New Listening / Music Bars — "Find the Venue"

The biggest opportunity. A newly opening listening/music bar is **a new venue type with no incumbent supplier**. Set up the craft, highball and natural-wine lines together at opening, and you become the long-term account. **Manager Hwang Hyun-woong finds new venues via SNS and local search.**

Sewang proposal — an opening package (base beers + highball kit + wine/sake curation), set up in one go (Contacts: Mgr. Hwang Hyun-woong / EVP Park Jung-eon)

CHANNEL 02



Music-Paired Dining & Izakaya — "Add a Corner"

Existing accounts can capture the after-dinner second round simply by **adding "a music corner."** One good speaker plus a **signature highball / sake pairing** raises both dwell time and per-head spend — making up for fewer guests with longer stays.

Sewang proposal — a highball kit + premium sake/Japanese-beer package to build a second-round menu (Contacts: EVP Lim Chang-soo / Dir. Chae Hyun-yong & Kim Hwan)

CHANNEL 03



Vinyl Pubs & Wine Bars — "Differentiate with Natural"

Vinyl pubs and wine bars in Haebangchon, Seongsu and Hannam run on **natural wine and craft beer**. Build regulars with **small-batch curation** matched to the music. In summer, light lagers and natural sparkling lift turnover.

Sewang proposal — natural wine + craft beer seasonal curation + a pairing guide (Contacts: SVP Son Seung-il / Vice-Chairman Lee Han-woo)

OUR PROMISE

The channels differ, the point is the same — **a listening bar isn't where you "sell a lot," it's where you "sell good things, slowly."** Sewang is not just a supplier but a partner in product, menu and promotion. New-venue intel and SNS trends are provided by GM Seong Hyun-woo.

Sources: this report's PART 01–05 analysis + Sewang's channel-level account data. Manager territory assignments may change — call HQ (+82-2-2203-5311) for first guidance.

Maximizing Venue Sales — Six Proposals for Listening Bars

Six ways to grow sales at listening bars and music-paired venues. Sewang executes alongside you with product, kits and consulting.

1

Sound + pairing as one set

Put a **signature pairing** matched to the music on the menu. "For this LP, this highball" curation lifts both dwell time and per-head spend.

Pairing menu

Signature

2

Signature highball kit

Whisky + tonic + glass as a **kit** = an instant signature highball. The tax cut sharpens price competitiveness. Sewang supplies the kit.

Kakubin

Glassware

Tax cut

3

Craft & Japanese-beer base line

Asahi, Suntory, Yona Yona as a **base line** for baseline sales — the most reliable turnover items for a listening bar.

Asahi

Craft

4

Natural wine & sake curation

Small-batch **natural wine and premium sake** with a story raise the unit price of lingering guests.

Natural wine

Premium sake

5

LP nights & guest events

DJ/selector guest days create **buzz and footfall**. Sewang supports events with season-limited drinks.

LP night

Limited drinks

6

Non-alcoholic to widen the base

The longer guests stay, the more **bottled non-alcoholic** captures drivers, daytime and health-minded guests. Sewang supplies the bottled line.

Bottled non-alc

Wider base

Our promise — we grow sales together

[▲ Grow together](#)

A listening bar is a venue for "**lingering long over one good drink.**" Sales come from curation, pairing and events — not volume. Sewang will be with you to the end through **product, kits, consulting and promotion** — that's how venues and Sewang grow together in a shrinking market.

About Sewang & Sales Manager Contacts

From hotels to restaurants across Seoul & Gyeonggi — your full-line liquor wholesale partner · founded 1978 · a 13-person sales team.

Sewang Corp.

Full-line liquor distribution to hotels, restaurants and bars in Seoul/Gyeonggi · founded 1978 · this report is for distribution to partners

CHANNELS

Hotels · fine dining · Korean bars · izakaya · listening/music bars · pojangmacha · lounge bars

CATEGORIES

Beer (Hite Jinro · OB · Lotte) · craft & import beer · non-alcoholic · whisky · wine & natural wine · sake · makgeolli · soju · traditional spirits

SERVICES

Weekly market report · new-venue scouting · partner SNS intelligence · new-product promotion/launch support · pairing consulting

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EVP	Park Jung-eon	010-3286-9489	Sales GM · report publishing lead
SVP	Son Seung-il	010-7539-3535	Seoul Yongsan · Hannam · Itaewon · Samgakji
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